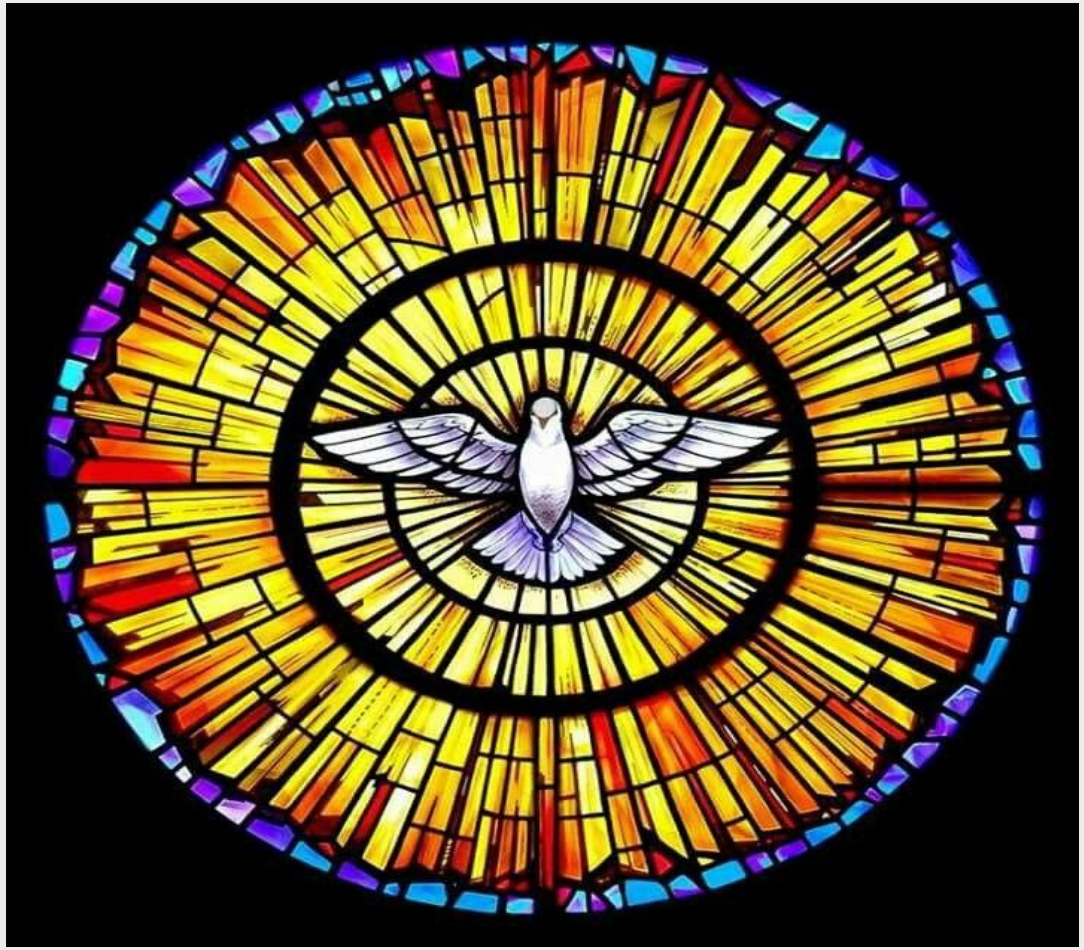


Doctrine of the Holy Spirit (*Pneumatology*) Weekend Class

Pneumatology

Course:- Doctrine of the Holy Spirit (*Pneumatology*)

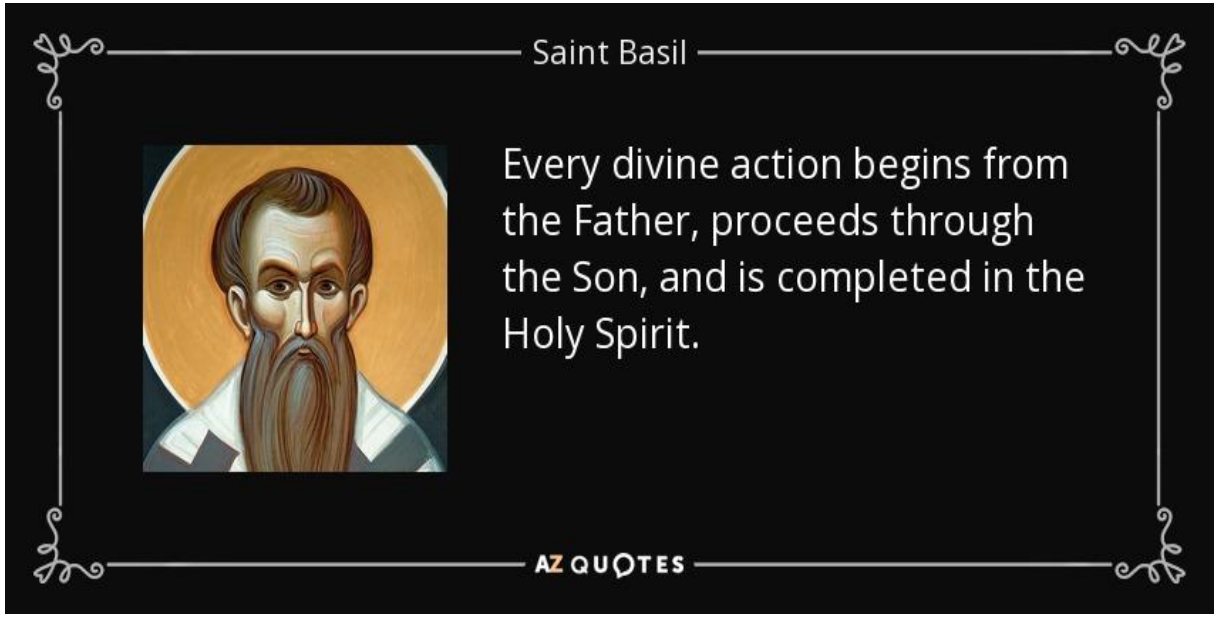
1. Etymology of Spirit
2. Spirit of God in the Old Testament
3. Holy Spirit in the New Testament
4. Pneumatological Heresies
5. Pneumatology of St. Athanasius of Alexandria
6. Pneumatology of Capadocian Fathers
7. Creedal Expressions Regarding Holy Spirit
8. Holy Spirit and the Holy Trinity
9. Consubstantiality of the Holy Spirit with the Father and Son
10. Procession of the Holy Spirit

"The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ… and the communion of the Holy Spirit be with you all."
2 Corinthians 13:14

Instructor: Elias Assefa elaasseffa@gmail.com

Learning objectives

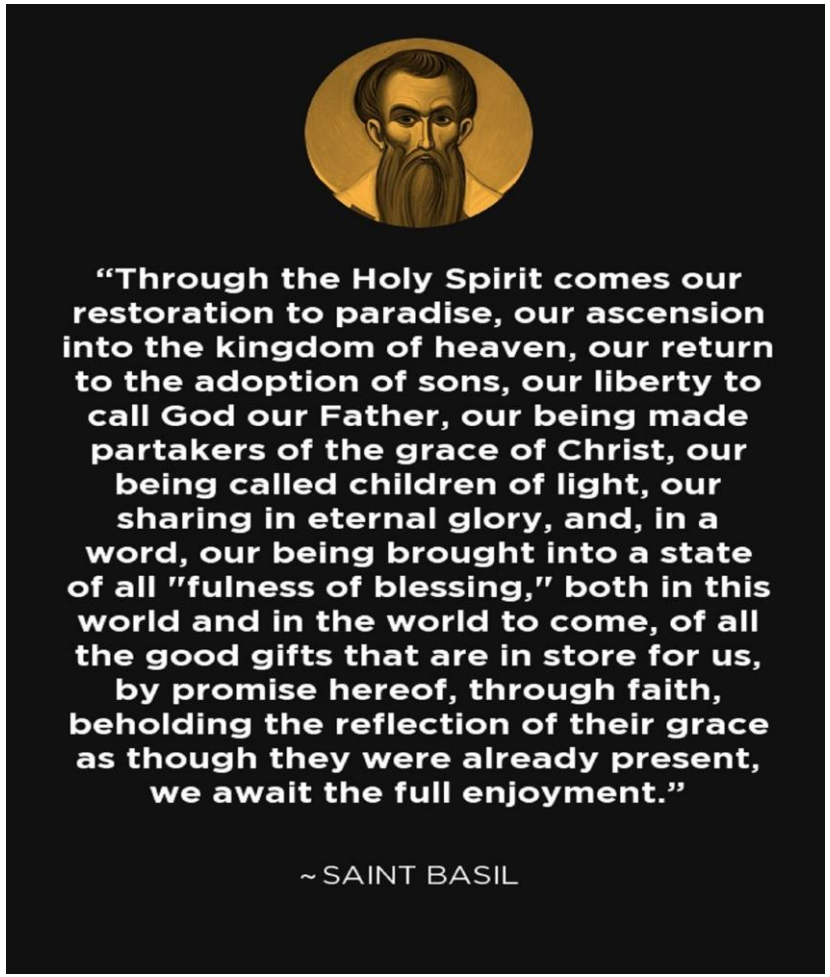
- Define “Pneumatology” and explain why the doctrine of the Holy Spirit is central not optional.
- Confess the Holy Spirit as fully God (consubstantial with the Father and the Son) and truly personal.
- Explain the Spirit’s eternal procession and His mission in time (Orthodox teaching).
- Trace the Spirit’s work across Scripture: creation, prophecy, Christ’s life, Pentecost, and the Church.
- Distinguish: gifts (charismata), fruit, filling, and sanctification (life of holiness / theosis).
- Apply: how to cooperate with the Spiritavoid grieving/quenching, grow in prayer and virtue.



Pneumatology

Scriptural and Dogmatic Foundations

- **The Procession of the Spirit:** Students will be able to explain the Orthodox understanding of the Spirit proceeding eternally from the Father alone (John 15:26) and contrast this with the Western ***Filioque*** clause.
- **Divinity and Personhood:** Identify the scriptural basis for the Holy Spirit's full divinity as the Third Person of the Holy Trinity, equal in essence to the Father and the Son.
- **The Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed:** Analyze the eighth article of the Creed to understand the specific titles given to the Spirit (Lord, Giver of Life, Spoke through the Prophets).



Pneumatology

The Spirit in the Economy of Salvation

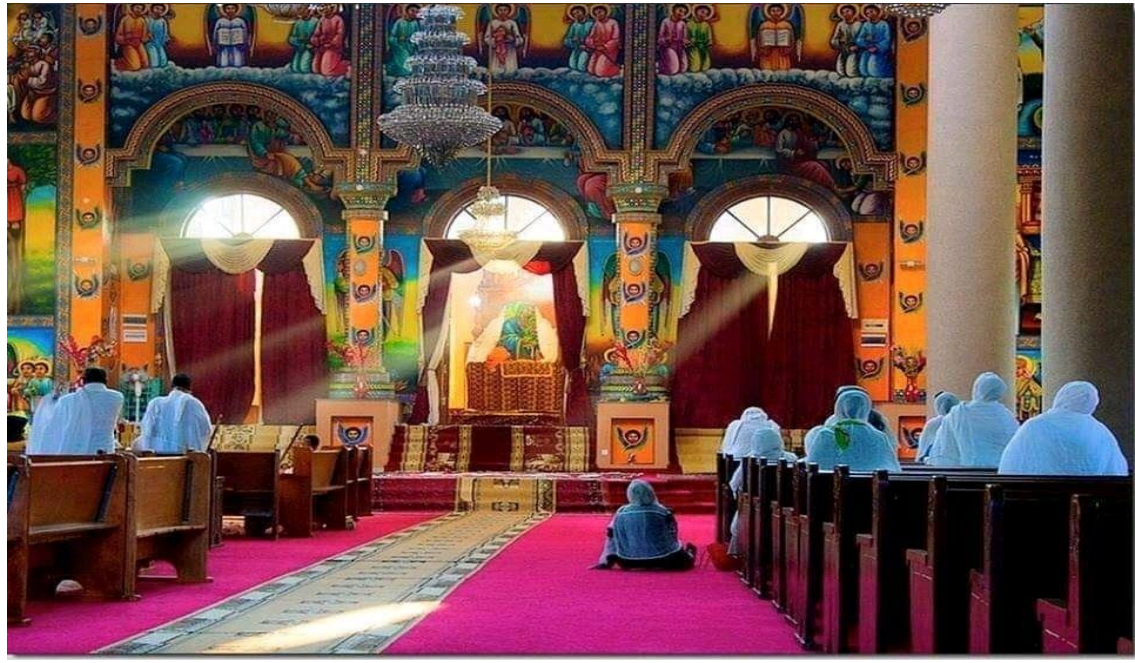
- **The Spirit and Christ:** Describe the relationship between the Spirit and the Incarnation, focusing on how the Spirit "prepared" the Virgin Mary and "anointed" Christ at His Baptism.
- **Pentecost as the "Birthday" of the Church:** Explain how the descent of the Holy Spirit transformed the Apostles and established the Church as the "Temple of the Living God."
- **The Spirit in Scripture:** Trace the activity of the Spirit from the "hovering" over the waters in Genesis to the "sighs too deep for words" in the Pauline epistles.



Pneumatology

Liturgical and Sacramental Presence

- **The Epiclesis:** Define the *Epiclesis* (the calling down of the Holy Spirit) in the Divine Liturgy and its role in the transformation of the Bread and Wine into the Body and Blood of Christ.
- **Chrismation:** Discuss the Sacrament of Chrismation as the "Personal Pentecost" for each believer, bestowing the "Seal of the Gift of the Holy Spirit.“
- **The Prayer "O Heavenly King":** Analyze the theology contained within this foundational prayer, focusing on the attributes of the Spirit as "everywhere present and filling all things."



St. Basil the Great: without the Spirit, the Liturgy is impossible. **The Spirit as the "Architect" of the Liturgy**

St. John Chrysostom: "When the priest stands before the table, lifting up his hands to heaven, calling upon the Holy Spirit to come and touch the elements... there is a great silence and awe. **The Epiclesis: The "Calling Down" of Fire**

Pneumatology

The Spiritual Life and Theosis

- **The Acquisition of the Spirit:** Summarize Seraphim of Sarov's teaching that the "true aim of our Christian life consists in the acquisition of the Holy Spirit."
- **Gifts vs. Fruits:** Distinguish between the *Charismata* (gifts for the building up of the Church) and the *Fruits of the Spirit* (internal evidence of a life lived in Christ).
- **Synergy (*Synergeia*):** Explain the Orthodox concept of synergy the cooperation between human will and Divine Grace (the Spirit) in the process of salvation.



Why Pneumatology matters

- Many confusions come from reducing the Spirit to "power" or "emotion." The Spirit is a Person.
- Without the Holy Spirit: Scripture remains closed, sacraments become empty forms, and spiritual life becomes moralism.
- The Spirit is the One who applies Christ's salvation to us (illumination, new birth, sanctification).
- Orthodox life is lived "in the Holy Spirit": prayer, worship, repentance, and love.



"The Spirit searches everything, even the depths of God."

1 Corinthians 2:10

Why Pneumatology matters

- The Oriental Orthodox Churches (including the Coptic, Ethiopian, Eritrean, Syrian, Armenian, and Malankara Orthodox Churches) hold a deeply Pneumatological or Spirit-centered theology. Their teachings are rooted in the first three Ecumenical Councils, particularly the Council of Constantinople (381 AD).



"The Spirit searches everything, even the depths of God." 1 Corinthians 2:10

What does “Holy Spirit” mean?

Names & titles in Scripture

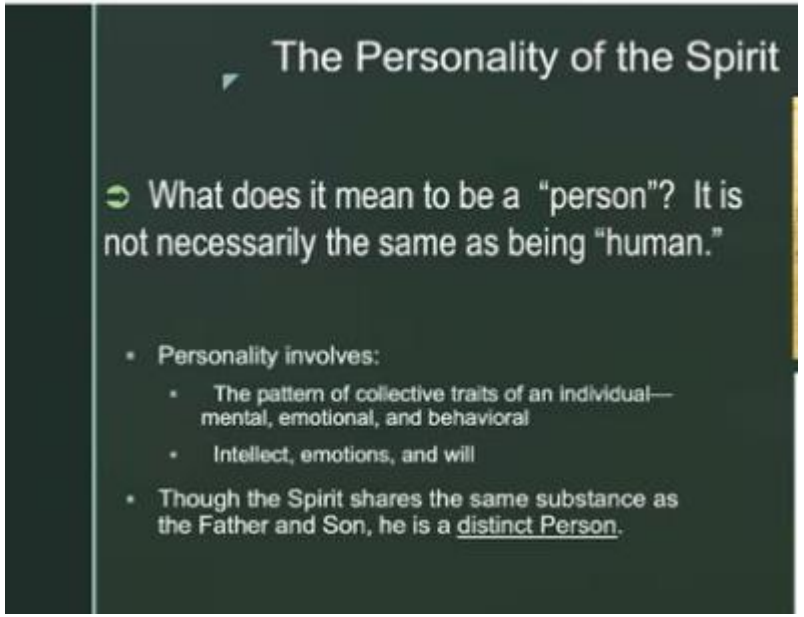
- Spirit of God / Spirit of the Lord (Gen 1:2; Isa 11:2)
- Spirit of truth (Jn 14:17)
- Paraclete / Comforter (Jn 14:16)
- Holy Spirit (Lk 11:13; Acts 1:8)

What the names teach us

- “Holy” → purity, consecration, separation from sin
- “Spirit” → life-giving, invisible, personal presence
- “Comforter/Helper” → teacher, advocate, strengthener
- “Truth” → guides the Church into true faith

The Holy Spirit is a Person (not an "it")

- He speaks (Acts 13:2), teaches (Jn 14:26), guides (Rom 8:14), and intercedes (Rom 8:26).
- He can be lied to (Acts 5:3–4), resisted (Acts 7:51), grieved (Eph 4:30), and quenched (1 Thess 5:19).
- Personhood means relationship: obedience, love, listening NOT manipulation.



"Do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption."

Ephesians 4:30

The Holy Spirit is fully God

- Divine names: "Spirit of God" (Gen 1:2), "Spirit of holiness" (Rom 1:4).
- Divine works: creation and life (Gen 1:2; Ps 104:30), inspiration of Scripture (2 Pet 1:21).
- Divine attributes: all-knowing (1 Cor 2:10–11), everywhere-present (Ps 139:7).
- Divine worship: we glorify the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit together in the Church's doxology.



"Why has Satan filled your heart…? You have not lied to men but to God."

Acts 5:3–4

Trinity: relations within the Godhead

Orthodox confession

- One God in three Persons: Father, Son, Holy Spirit.
- Father: unbegotten Source (Cause).
- Son: eternally begotten of the Father.
- Spirit: eternally proceeds from the Father.

Mission in time

- The Father sends the Spirit in the Son's name (Jn 14:26).
- The Son sends the Spirit "from the Father" (Jn 15:26).
- The Spirit reveals Christ and makes Him present in the Church.
- All divine acts are Trinitarian: from the Father, through the Son, in the

"The Spirit of truth… proceeds from the Father; He will bear witness about Me."

John 15:26

Old Testament: the Spirit gives life and orders creation

- Creation: the Spirit "hovered" over the waters (Gen 1:2).
- Life: God breathes life (Gen 2:7) breath/wind as symbol of life.
- Providence: "You send forth Your Spirit, they are created" (Ps 104:30).
- Wisdom and order: the Spirit equips people for God's work (craftsmanship, leadership).

"By the word of the LORD the heavens were made… and by the breath of His mouth all their host."

Psalm 33:6

Old Testament: Spirit and prophecy

- Prophets speak by the Spirit: the Spirit comes upon them, empowers, and reveals God's word.
- Messianic prophecy includes Spirit imagery: the coming Messiah is anointed by the Spirit (Isa 11:2; 61:1).
- Promise: God will pour out His Spirit (Joel 2:28–29) → fulfilled at Pentecost.

"The Spirit of the LORD shall rest upon Him…"

Isaiah 11:2

The Holy Spirit and the Incarnate Son

- Incarnation: “The Holy Spirit will come upon you” (Lk 1:35).
- Baptism: Spirit descends like a dove (Lk 3:22).
- Christ’s ministry: Jesus is “anointed” by the Spirit (Lk 4:18; Acts 10:38).
- Christ’s obedience and sacrifice are offered “through the eternal Spirit” (Heb 9:14).

“God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power.”

Acts 10:38

Pentecost: the Spirit constitutes the Church

- Pentecost is the public descent of the Spirit on the Church (Acts 2).
- The Church is not merely an organization: she is a living Body by the Spirit.
- The Spirit gives bold witness, repentance, and baptism into Christ (Acts 2:38).
- Fire and wind show purification and power for mission.

"They were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak…"

Acts 2:4

The Holy Spirit in the Sacraments (Orthodox focus)

- Baptism: we are born of water and the Spirit (Jn 3:5).
- Chrismation: sealing with the gift of the Holy Spirit (Eph 1:13).
- Eucharist: in the epiclesis we ask the Father to send the Spirit to sanctify the Gifts and the people.
- Repentance/Confession: the Spirit restores fellowship and heals the heart.
- Marriage and ordination: the Spirit establishes and consecrates.

"The love of God has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit."

Romans 5:5

The Holy Spirit and Scripture

Inspiration

- Prophets and apostles spoke as they were carried by the Spirit (2 Pet 1:21).
- The Church receives Scripture in the Spirit and reads it in the Spirit.
- "The Holy Spirit says…" (Heb 3:7) Scripture is His testimony.

Illumination

- The Spirit opens the mind and convicts the heart.
- He protects from private, prideful interpretation.
- Prayer + obedience are conditions for true understanding.

"No prophecy of Scripture comes from someone's own interpretation… men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit."

2 Peter 1:20–21

Symbols of the Holy Spirit

- Breath/Wind: life and power (Gen 2:7; Jn 3:8; Acts 2:2).
- Dove: gentleness, peace, love (Lk 3:22; Gen 8:8–12).
- Oil/Anointing: consecration, illumination (1 Sam 16:13; Lk 4:18).
- Fire: purification, zeal, bold witness (Acts 2:3–4).
- Water: cleansing and life (Jn 7:37–39).
- Seal/Earnest: ownership + pledge of inheritance (Eph 1:13–14).

Spiritual gifts (charismata): purpose and definition

- A spiritual gift is a grace-endowment given by the Holy Spirit for service in the Body of Christ.
- Gifts are diverse but the Spirit is one (1 Cor 12:4–11).
- Purpose: "for the common good" (1 Cor 12:7) not self-glory.
- Orthodox principle: gifts must serve love, humility, and unity in the Church.

"To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good."

1 Corinthians 12:7

Key gift lists in the New Testament

1 Corinthians 12 (examples)

- wisdom, knowledge, faith
- healings, miracles
- prophecy, discernment
- tongues & interpretation

Romans 12 / Ephesians 4

- service, teaching, exhortation
- giving, leadership, mercy
- apostles, prophets, evangelists
- pastors/teachers (for building up)

"All these are empowered by one and the same Spirit, who apportions to each one individually as He wills."

1 Corinthians 12:11

Discerning and ordering the gifts

- Not every spiritual "experience" is from God—discernment is itself a gift (1 Cor 12:10).
- Love is the measure: gifts without love profit nothing (1 Cor 13).
- The Church seeks edification: intelligibility, peace, and order in worship (1 Cor 14:26–33).
- Spiritual authority grows with humility, repentance, and obedience not with noise.

"Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits…"

1 John 4:1

Fruit of the Spirit: the normal evidence of life in the Spirit

- Fruit ≠ gifts. Fruit is character formed by grace through cooperation (synergy).
- Fruit of the Spirit (Gal 5:22–23): love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control.
- Orthodox aim: holiness and theosis becoming by grace what God is by nature (without confusion).

"If we live by the Spirit, let us also keep in step with the Spirit."

Galatians 5:25

Grieving and quenching the Holy Spirit

- To “grieve” the Spirit is to wound the relationship by sin and stubbornness (Eph 4:30).
- To “quench” is to suppress His fire resisting His conviction and guidance (1 Thess 5:19).
- Consequences: loss of joy, spiritual authority, and clarity; the Spirit becomes “silent” to the hardened heart.
- Remedy: confession, repentance, and renewed surrender (1 Jn 1:9).

“Filled with the Holy Spirit” what it means

- Command: “Be filled with the Spirit” (Eph 5:18).
- Meaning: not “more Spirit” as a quantity, but the Spirit possessing more of us (surrender).
- Examples in Acts: Peter, Stephen, the deacons, the whole community (Acts 4:31; 7:55).
- Signs: boldness, purity, wisdom, prayer, and love.

“Be filled with the Spirit… giving thanks…”

Ephesians 5:18–20

The Holy Spirit and prayer

- The Spirit teaches us to pray and intercedes with “groanings too deep for words” (Rom 8:26).
- Orthodox prayer life: “O Heavenly King, Comforter…” inviting the Spirit to dwell in us.
- Prayer in the Spirit includes repentance, tears, thanksgiving, and silence.
- We do not command God; we ask, we repent, we listen.

“The Spirit helps us in our weakness…”

Romans 8:26

The Spirit and worship (doxology)

- Orthodox worship is Trinitarian: to the Father, with the Son, together with the Holy Spirit.
- The Spirit makes worship "in spirit and truth" (Jn 4:23–24).
- He unites the Church into one voice and one heart.
- True worship produces humility, compassion, and holiness.

"Where the Spirit's grace operates on us, we say the Spirit is "in us.""

St Basil, On the Holy Spirit (summary)

The Spirit builds unity and holiness in the Church

- The Spirit constitutes the Church and makes her God's temple (Eph 2:22).
- Unity is not uniformity: many gifts, one Body (1 Cor 12).
- Holiness is communal: the Spirit forms one people, not isolated "spiritual heroes."
- Schism, gossip, and pride directly oppose the Spirit's work.

"You also are being built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit."

Ephesians 2:22

The Spirit and mission (witness to Christ)

- The Spirit's primary work is to glorify Christ and bear witness to Him (Jn 15:26; 16:14).
- Mission is not marketing; it is Spirit-empowered witness (Acts 1:8).
- The Spirit convicts the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment (Jn 16:8).
- Orthodox witness: truth + love + holiness; the Gospel is seen in transformed lives.

"You will receive power… and you will be My witnesses."

Acts 1:8

Spiritual warfare and discernment

- The Spirit strengthens against passions and demonic deception.
- Discernment: test by Scripture, by the Church's Tradition, and by the fruits (humility, peace, repentance).
- Avoid extremes: (1) denying the Spirit's work; (2) chasing signs and neglecting holiness.
- Practical: confession, fasting, prayer, Eucharist, and obedience to a spiritual father.

"Walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh."

Galatians 5:16

Common misconceptions (and Orthodox corrections)

- Misconception: “The Spirit is only a feeling.” → Correction: He is a divine Person.
- Misconception: “Gifts prove holiness.” → Correction: fruit and humility are the measure.
- Misconception: “Spirituality = experiences.” → Correction: spirituality = communion with God + obedience.
- Misconception: “I can have the Spirit without the Church.” → Correction: the Spirit constitutes the Church and works sacramentally.

Witness of the Fathers (accepted Orthodox sources)

- St Basil the Great: the Spirit is glorified with the Father and the Son in doxology; worship expresses doctrine.
- St Athanasius: the Spirit is not a creature; He sanctifies and gives life, which only God can do.
- St Cyril of Alexandria: blessings are "from the Father, through the Son, in the Spirit."
- The Church's prayer life confesses the Spirit as "everywhere present and filling all things."

> *""From the Father, through the Son, in the Spirit.""*
>
> St Cyril of Alexandria (summary)

Orthodox prayer: “O Heavenly King”

O Heavenly King, Comforter, Spirit of Truth,
Who are everywhere present and fill all things;
Treasury of blessings and Giver of life,
Come and abide in us, and cleanse us from every impurity,
And save our souls, O Good One.

Discussion & reflection questions

- How do you distinguish “gift” from “fruit” in your own spiritual life?
- What does it look like to “grieve” the Spirit in daily habits (speech, anger, impurity, pride)?
- In Orthodox life, where do you encounter the Spirit most clearly (liturgy, sacraments, Scripture, prayer)?
- How can the Church keep both order and openness to the Spirit’s gifts?
- What is one concrete act of repentance to “open the vessel” for the Spirit’s filling?

Summary and assignment

- Confession: The Holy Spirit is fully God and truly personal.
- Doctrine: He proceeds from the Father; He is sent in time through the Son; He glorifies Christ.
- Life: He gives new birth, sanctifies, builds the Church, and equips us with gifts for service.
- Practice: do not grieve/quench—repent, pray, receive the sacraments, and pursue the fruit of the Spirit.

Assignment (1–2 pages):
Explain John 15:26 in Orthodox teaching (procession vs sending).
Add 3 Bible citations + 1 Father (Basil/Athanasius/Cyril).